

The Aetherium Codex: World Bible (Version 4)

Part I: The Metaphysical Foundation

The Great Truth & The Great Lie

- **The Great Truth:** Tessera is not a natural world. It is a "patchwork reality" stitched together by the Overdeity Aíon following a cataclysm that destroyed two previous realities ("Setting A" - Ancient Sword & Sorcery, and "Setting B" - Magitech/WWII-era). The world is built from the "sanitized" conceptual fragments of terrifying, primordial forces known as **The Lacunae**.
- **The Great Lie:** The unified, coherent narrative maintained by the Generalist College (The Church of Aíon) to prevent mass cognitive dissonance and the unraveling of reality. It presents history as a continuous, logical progression, hiding the seams where the worlds were merged.
- **The Smoothing Effect:** A cosmic triage. Aíon stripped incompatible concepts of their true names (creating The Lacunae) and imposed the **Law of Duality**, linking opposing concepts intrinsically to force balance.

The Three Pockets of History

1. **Setting A (The Ancient World):** Foundational geography and "native" magic. Represented by ancient ruins, sword-and-sorcery traditions, and the **Elder Fey** (melancholic echoes of nature myths).
2. **Setting B (The Lost World):** Isolated pockets of advanced magitech and logic-based magic. Represented by "out of place" cities, strange ruins, and the **Lost Fey** (fragmented, glitching narratives).
3. **The Third Blending (The Present):** The messy, vibrant fusion of the two. Represented by the **Newborn Fey** (living urban legends/folklore) and current geopolitics.

Part II: The Physics of Magic

1. The Primal Current (Anima's Influence)

- **Nature:** The raw, chaotic "lifeblood" of the planet. Radiates from the core and magically charged materials.
- **Sources:** Natural Wellsprings, Reality Seams (Setting A/B merge points), and Planar Infusions.

Expression: Primal Loci (The Source Points)

- **Tier 1: Resonant (Common):** Subtle enhancement (e.g., **Resonant Witchwood**).
- **Tier 2: True (Uncommon):** Distinct magical properties (e.g., **Glimmersteel**, **Singing**).

Stone).

- **Tier 3: Prime (Legendary):** Semi-sentient, adaptive materials found in Primal Hearts (e.g., **Animus Geodes**).

2. The Structured Current (Kanon's Influence)

- **The Tokamak Analogy:** Kanon is not "emitted" by the gods intentionally. The Grand Orrery of Ætherna is a nuclear reactor (Tokamak) processing the raw power of Fate. The Structured Current is the **waste heat** of this engine. It is the ambient byproduct of the Fates doing their job.
- **The Paradox (The Magic of Choice):** While derived from "Inevitability," Kanon is paradoxically the magic of *agency*. By mastering the rigid laws of the machine, a mage learns where the gears slip. It is the art of using Law to rewrite Destiny.

The Spectrum of Flow (Magical Weather)

Ley lines exist in dual states (Laminar/Turbulent) across three intensities:

- **Trace (Murmur/Static):** Background hum vs. minor annoyance.
- **Current (Channel/Rapids):** Standard casting vs. dangerous surges.
- **Torrent (Deluge/Cascade):** Infinite power vs. magical natural disaster.

3. The Metaphysics of Casting (Spark vs. Capacitor)

All beings possess an internal **Spark** of Anima. The difference lies in how they utilize it.

- **Studied Magic (Kanon): The Capacitor Model.** The Spark acts as a **Key** to unlock external floodgates (Ley Lines). Attribute: **Intelligence/Wisdom** (Capacitance/Control).
- **Innate Magic (Anima): The Reactor Model.** The Spark acts as a **Muscle**. The caster cultivates internal power, growing it into a self-sustaining bonfire. Attribute: **Constitution** (Tolerance/Burnout Resistance).

Part III: Planar Ecology & Materials

The Lifecycle of a Planar Tear (The Mutagenic Process)

When reality tears, the healing process creates monsters.

1. **Stage 1: The Breach (Anima's Flood):** The tear opens, flooding the area with raw, unfiltered radiation. Instant death or immediate mutation for soft tissue.
2. **Stage 2: The Adaptation (The Divine Band-Aid):** Flora and fauna rapidly mutate to survive the hostile environment. This is the origin of **Aberrations**—life forcing itself to fit a wrong reality.
3. **Stage 3: The Stabilization (The Scar):** The Structured Current naturally "scabs over" the wound. The tear becomes a stable **Manifest Zone**, and the mutated creatures become a permanent part of the local ecosystem.

Planar Leakage Effects

- **Prime Cog (Crucible of Artifice):** Leaks *The Spark of Innovation*. Machines run at 200%

- efficiency; users receive flashes of genius but lose the wisdom to foresee consequences.
- **Palimpsest Dust (Transitive Plane):** Leaks *Pure Potential*. Causes wild magic; disrupts divination.
- **Heartwood Seed (Verdant Font):** Leaks *Uncontrolled Growth*. Explodes into invasive alien ecosystems.
- **Athenaeum Salt (Silent Athenaeum):** Leaks *Stasis*. Preserves objects; mutes emotions.
- **Generative Cores (Borderlands):** Leaks *Primal Instability*. Elemental wild magic.
- **Concordance Vellum (The Concordance):** Leaks *Conceptual Rigidity*. Forces literal interpretations.
- **Regalite (Crucible of Kings):** Leaks *Command*. Radiates authority; suppresses dissent.

Part IV: The Cold War Against Reality

The Architect: The Generalist College

- **Secret Identity:** The Church of Aíon.
- **Structure:** Overt Police Force vs. Covert Intelligence ("The Unseen Hand").

The Three Fronts & The Strategic Theaters

1. **The Physical Front (War on Instability):**
 - *Agents:* Wildpath Wardens (Field Ops), Stormpeak (Heavy Support).
2. **The Informational Front (War on Perception):**
 - *Agents:* Chiaroscuro (Propaganda), Unity (Loyalty).
 - *Theater: The Wellspring of Stories* (The battle for the collective unconscious).
3. **The Conceptual Front (War on Fate):**
 - *Agents:* Chronosynclastic Institute (Intel), Mortis Aevum (Healers/Keepers).
 - *Theater: The Living Archive.* The Mortis Aevum catalogues the memories of the dead. **Secretly**, the Generalist College maintains a deep-cover network of "Editors" here who alter these soul-memories before filing, ensuring the past aligns with the Great Lie.

The Aionic Accords (Rules of Engagement)

1. **Prime Directive:** The Narrative Must Be Maintained.
2. **Acceptable Losses:** The Mission outweighs the Asset.
3. **Containment Imperative:** Study first, destroy last.
4. **Protocol of Veiled Contact:** Plausible deniability.
5. **The Unspoken Sanction:** Assassination is forbidden... unless "Resolving a Variable" is necessary.

Part V: The Public Face of the Secret War

The Colleges and Churches cannot act openly. These are the "Legitimate" organizations that adventurers join, acting as proxies in the Cold War.

1. The Prospecting Guild (The Wildpath Front)

- **Public Face:** A rough-and-tumble guild of monster hunters, guides, and resource surveyors. They keep the roads safe and the mines open.
- **Secret Mission:** "Containment and Sampling." They are the first responders to Reality Seams. They silence witnesses of "impossible beasts" and secure dangerous biological samples for the Colleges.

2. The Crimson Compass (The Neutral Agents)

- **Public Face:** An elite society of cartographers and explorers dedicated to mapping the "New World."
- **Secret Mission:** They map the "places that don't exist." As the only true neutral faction, they sell data on unstable zones to both the Colleges and the highest bidder. They are the brokers of the "Truth."

3. The Legion of the Gilded Sun (The King's Eyes)

- **Public Face:** The gleaming, heroic military arm of the Church of Aurelion. They act as Royal Guards and peacekeepers in major cities.
- **Secret Mission:** Political Destabilization. They are the enforcers of the Monarchy against the Colleges. They stage "magical accidents" to justify martial law and seize artifacts for the Crown, not the Church.

Part VI: Factions & Extremist Ideologies

The Cosmic Conflict

- **The Entropics (Demons/Devils):** Champions of **The Great Truth** (Chaos/Unmaking).
- **The Architects (Angels/Inevitables):** Champions of **The Great Lie** (Stasis/Utopia).

The Universal Threat: Cults of the Lacuna

- **Type A: The Restorationists (Warlocks):** Worship specific, named Lacunae (e.g., The Whispered One, The Rotting King).
 - *Goal:* To restore a specific lost god or concept from the erased timelines. They want to overwrite the present with *their* past.
- **Type B: The Nihilists (Cult of Unmaking):** Worship the abstract Void; the antithesis of Aíon.
 - *Goal:* They do not want to restore the past; they want to erase the future. They seek total dissolution of the "Painful Lie."

College-Specific Extremists

- **Sovereign Exchange: The Planar Cartel.** Anarcho-capitalists.
- **Chiaroscuro Institute: The Argent Coil** (Liberationists) & **Utopian Visionaries.**
- **Unity Academy: The Unifiers.** Hive-mind supremacists.

- **Stormpeak Command: The Aegis of Purity.** Xenophobes (Anti-Tech / Anti-Magic).
- **Mortis Aevum: Keepers of the Still Verse.** Nihilists seeking static undeath.
- **Wildpath Wardens: Primalists** (Return to Nature) & **The Ascended** (Mutation Worship).
- **Deepguard Academy: The Arbiters.** Vigilante judges.
- **Chronosynclastic: The Oracular Covenant.** Fatalists forcing a "Final Timeline."

Part VII: The Mortal Perspective (The "Everyman" Reality)

The Mundane Leakage

How the common folk rationalize the Cold War.

- **"The Glimmer Man":** A Chiaroscuro propaganda myth used to explain away memory wipes. "Don't stay out past the bells, or the Glimmer Man will take your yesterdays."
- **"Fickle Land":** The rural term for Reality Seams. When gravity shifts or crops grow purple, farmers don't call the police; they check the almanac and wait for the "weather" to pass.
- **"Lucky Iron":** Common slang for Finding Resonant materials. It's not seen as magic, just a good payday.

Adventurers: Deniable Assets

Adventurers are the "free radicals" used by great powers for dirty work.

- **Divine Churches:** Use "The Legion" for covert ops.
- **College Contractors:** Use "The Prospecting Guild" for wetwork.
- **Mortal Kingdoms:** Proxy wars between nations are often fronts for College ideology wars.

Part VIII: Questions for Future Development

Group 1: Society & Culture

1. **The New Economy:** How have Primal Loci materials and Setting B magi-tech created new industries?
2. **Culture Clash:** How do daily life/food/art blend in mixed cities?
3. **The Aether-Touched:** How does this "bloodline" impact social hierarchy?
4. **Law:** How do courts handle reality-warping crimes?

Group 2: Magic & The Practitioner

1. **Sōmaturgy:** Is it viewed as Truth or Corruption?
2. **Warlock Pacts:** What is the mechanical/narrative process?
3. **Summoning:** Respected science or reckless danger?
4. **Ætherforged Precepts:** How do martial arts align with factions?
5. **Burnouts:** What happens to broken agents?

Group 3: Factions & Politics

1. **Recruitment:** How do extremists recruit without exposure?
2. **Dragons:** Are they players or masters?
3. **Underworld:** Is there a "thieves' code" for the Cartel?
4. **Schisms:** What does a Generalist civil war look like?
5. **Doomsday Clock:** Is there a metric for narrative collapse?